

4NL3 Project Step 1

Team Members

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Annotation Details

Concise Overview of the Annotator's Job

The annotator's task is to analyze a book blurb and determine the author's tone.

The Set of Tones an Annotator Can Choose From

1. **Optimistic (0)** - Works centred on positive possibilities, solutions, and a brighter future.
2. **Humorous (1)** - Works that feature funny and unexpected characters, twists, or settings.
3. **Suspenseful (2)** - Works that build tension and anticipation, keeping readers on edge.
4. **Inspirational (3)** - Works that encourage and uplift readers, focusing on perseverance and hope.
5. **Poetic (4)** - Works designed to evoke dramatic feelings through the use of metrical language.
6. **Pessimistic (5)** - Works that convey doubt, negativity, and a negative outlook on situations.
7. **Informative (6)** - Works that focus on educating the reader and providing factual information.

Each number next to a tone represents its index in the interface program, allowing the annotator to select the corresponding label easily.

Rules to Follow When Labelling

1. Identify the central tone/mood. Read the blurb carefully and determine the primary emotion the text conveys.
 - a. To do this, pay attention to:
 - i. **Diction:** Look for words or phrases that carry strong emotional or thematic connotations:
 1. **Optimistic (0)** - Words like "a brighter future," "new possibilities," "against all odds," "progress."
 2. **Humorous (1)** - Words like "hilarity ensues," "quirky," "mishap," "unlikely duo."
 3. **Suspenseful (2)** - Words like "danger," "mystery," "uncover the truth," "race against time."
 4. **Inspirational (3)** - Words like "perseverance," "inspires," "dreams," "achieves greatness."
 5. **Poetic (4)** - Words like "whispers," "lyrical," "river of dreams," "fleeting."
 6. **Pessimistic (5)** - Words like "despair," "no way out," "loss," "it's all over," "falling apart."
 7. **Informative (6)** - Words like "analysis," "explores the history," "comprehensive guide," "reveals," "resource," "detailed insights."
 - ii. **Sentence Structure:** Syntax impacts how a sentence conveys a particular tone, mood, or emotional response.
 1. **Optimistic (0)** - Sentences are often straightforward and forward-looking.
 2. **Humorous (1)** - Sentences may use playful structures, puns, or unexpected twists. There is often a back-and-forth in rhythm or juxtaposition of ideas, creating humour.
 3. **Suspenseful (2)** - Sentences are often short or fragmented, and may become increasingly disjointed or clipped. Pacing can change, creating tension and anticipation.
 4. **Inspirational (3)** - Sentences are often uplifting and motivational, with a focus on overcoming challenges. The structure can be parallel or emphatic, with repeated ideas to inspire action.
 5. **Poetic (4)** - Sentences tend to be rhythmic, lyrical, and flowing, often with varied lengths and a focus on sound. The sentence structure creates a sense of fluidity and musicality.
 6. **Pessimistic (5)** - Sentences may feel heavy, or slow - drawn out, with lots of pauses or long-winded phrases that emphasize doubt or despair.

7. **Informative (6)** - Sentences are typically clear, concise, and to the point. The structure is often straightforward and focused on delivering facts or instructions.

- b. Other Considerations:
 - i. Does the blurb include exclamation marks, question marks or ellipses which can heighten excitement, create suspense or suggest emphasis?
 - ii. Is there selective capitalization which conveys intensity or heightened emotion?
 - iii. Does the author use comparisons, symbolism, or vivid imagery? What mood is being conveyed?
 - iv. What is the subject matter or context of the work?
 - v. What is the point of view or perspective?
 - vi. Is the author trying to persuade, inform, entertain, or reflect?
2. Ignore any influence from genres.
 - a. Do not focus on the genre. For instance, a thriller may have a humorous tone.
3. Avoid personal biases, like "I have a feeling this book is about this." Focus strictly on clues you receive from the text.
4. Choose the primary, dominant tone.
 - a. If multiple tones are present, choose the most prominent one in the blurb.

Examples of Labelling

Optimistic

Example

"When the spoiled and bad-tempered Mary is orphaned at the age of ten, she is sent from India to live with her hunchback uncle on the Yorkshire Moors. At first, she is utterly miserable, but gradually the friendship of her maid and the discovery of a secret garden in the grounds of the house begin to change her..."

EXPLANATION

The optimistic tone is created through the emphasis on personal transformation and the hopeful possibilities that arise from Mary's situation. Specific elements that contribute to this tone include:

"but gradually the friendship of her maid and the discovery of a secret garden in the grounds of the house begin to change her..."

- Words like "gradually," "change," and "discovery" convey a sense of progress and transformation.

"When the spoiled and bad-tempered Mary is orphaned at the age of ten, she is sent from India to live with her hunchback uncle on the Yorkshire Moors."

- The blurb shows positive development over time by contrasting Mary's initial misery and her eventual transformation. This shift from a negative to a positive state reinforces the optimistic tone.

"the house begin to change her..."

- The use of ellipsis in this blurb contributes to the optimistic tone by creating a sense of anticipation. It creates a sense that Mary's journey has only just begun, and more positive changes are to come.

This blurb could also be interpreted as Inspirational. While the blurb hints at positive change, it focuses more on gradual transformation and the new beginnings in Mary's life rather than directly encouraging the reader to take action or push through adversity. The optimistic tone highlights hope and growth but doesn't emphasize motivating the reader in an active, inspirational way.

Humorous

Example

"In each episode of their podcast By the Book, Jolenta Greenberg and Kristen Meinzer take a deep dive into a different self-help book, following its specific instructions, rules, and advice to the letter. From diet and productivity to decorating to social interactions, they try it all, record themselves along the way, then share what they've learned with their devoted audience. In this funny, revealing book, Jolenta and Kristen synthesize the lessons and insights they've learned and tell their stories. How to Be Fine is a thoughtful look at the books and practices that have worked, real talk on those that didn't, and a list of philosophies they want to see explored in-depth. "

EXPLANATION

This blurb implies a lighthearted and funny approach rather than a strict analysis. The tone suggests a mix of humour and self-reflection. Specific elements that contribute to this tone include:

"They try it all, record themselves along the way, then share what they've learned."

- A comedic aspect is implied with the content where the authors are engaging in sometimes absurd or over-the-top activities in the name of self-improvement, making it clear that the work is more about entertainment than serious self-help.

"In this funny, revealing book..."

- Directly states that the book is funny or has a humorous tone.

"Real talk on those that didn't."

- The playful diction in the blurb creates humor by using casual, conversational language which contrasts with the seriousness of the self-help genre. This creates an opportunity for unintentional comedy.

The other obvious tones may be Optimistic or Inspirational. Optimistic isn't the best fit because while it explores self-improvement, the tone focuses on humor and critique rather than pure positivity. It also may come across as Inspirational, but the playful tone is more about entertainment than motivation.

Suspenseful

Example

"Kira Navárez dreamed of life on new worlds. Now she's awakened a nightmare. During a routine survey mission on an uncolonized planet, Kira finds an alien relic. At first she's delighted, but elation turns to terror when the ancient dust around her begins to move. As war erupts among the stars, Kira is launched into a galaxy-spanning odyssey of discovery and transformation. First contact isn't at all what she imagined, and events push her to the very limits of what it means to be human. While Kira faces her own horrors, Earth and its colonies stand upon the brink of annihilation. Now, Kira might be humanity's greatest and final hope."

EXPLANATION

This blurb builds tension and anticipation, making the reader eager to find out what happens next. The story has unexpected discoveries, escalating danger, and high stakes, all elements of suspense. Specific elements that contribute to this tone include:

"Now she's awakened a nightmare."

- The words "nightmare," "terror," "erupts," immediately create a sense of foreboding and tension, signalling that something dangerous and unexpected is about to unfold, creating suspense.

"At first she's delighted, but elation turns to terror when the ancient dust around her begins to move."

- The shift from delight to terror further builds a feeling of unease and anticipation, as the danger quickly escalates.

"Kira might be humanity's greatest and final hope"

- The phrase "greatest and final hope" conveys high stakes, implying that everything hinges on Kira's actions, heightening the suspense around her journey and the challenges she will face.

The other possible tone could be Pessimistic, especially since some phrases suggest that things are dire and the world is on the brink of annihilation. However, the blurb also focuses on the potential for hope, leaving the tone more suspenseful.

Inspirational

Example

"Our generation is realistic, for we have come to know man as he really is. After all, man is the being who invented the gas chambers of Auschwitz; however he is also the being who entered those gas chambers upright, with the Lord's Prayer or the Shema Yisrael on his lips."

EXPLANATION

This blurb emphasizes human resilience, strength in the face of adversity, and the power of faith, which aligns with an inspirational tone. Specific elements that contribute to this tone include:

"man is the being who invented the gas chambers of Auschwitz; however, he is also the being who entered those gas chambers upright, with the Lord's Prayer or the Shema Yisrael on his lips."

- The contrast in the sentence structure—first presenting humanity's capacity for evil, then immediately following it with the image of people entering the gas chambers with prayer—creates a sense of balance and hope. This reversal of expectations emphasizes the spiritual triumph over suffering.

"with the Lord's Prayer or the Shema Yisrael on his lips"

- Words like "upright," "prayer," and "lips" convey a sense of dignity and faith. These choices evoke a feeling of strength and spiritual resilience, uplifting the reader.

The other possible tone may be Pessimistic. The blurb touches on the evil of humanity, symbolized by the gas chambers, which could convey a sense of negativity or hopelessness. The message of hope, faith, and inner strength isn't overshadowed though, which keeps the overall tone inspirational rather than purely pessimistic.

Poetic

Example

"The circus arrives without warning. No announcements precede it. It is simply there, when yesterday it was not."

EXPLANATION

The passage from "The Night Circus" conveys a poetic tone through its elevated diction and rhythmic flow. Key elements include:

"The circus arrives without warning."

- The phrasing itself is deliberate and calm, with a steady rhythm that contrasts with the surprise of the circus's appearance, adding to the mystery.

"No announcements precede it."

- The rhythmic brevity of each sentence contributes to the overall smooth flow, typical of poetic language.

"It is simply there, when yesterday it was not."

- The repetition of "simply" and "not" creates a rhythmic balance, giving the sentence a musical, almost haiku-like quality. The contrast between "yesterday" and "not" enhances the poetic tone.

This blurb could also be interpreted as having a Suspenseful tone. While there's an element of mystery, the tone is primarily poetic, emphasizing the dreamlike and intriguing nature of the circus, rather than suspense, which would typically focus on danger or anticipation.

Pessimistic

Example

"Set in the oppressive superstate of Oceania, this chilling novel introduces readers to Winston Smith, a man struggling to maintain his humanity in a society ruled by the ever-watchful Big Brother. As Winston becomes increasingly disillusioned with the Party's brutal control over every aspect of life, he finds solace in a secret love affair with the enigmatic Julia, putting both of them in the crosshairs of an unforgiving regime."

EXPLANATION

The pessimistic tone in this blurb contributes to a sense of hopelessness, oppression, and despair. Specific elements that contribute to this tone include:

"Set in the oppressive superstate of Oceania, this chilling novel introduces readers to Winston Smith, a man struggling to maintain his humanity"

- Words like "chilling", "struggling", and "disillusioned" immediately convey a sense of unease and frustration.

"putting both of them in the crosshairs of an unforgiving regime."

- The imagery of the "crosshairs of an unforgiving regime" is militaristic and fatalistic, which paints a picture of imminent danger and persecution, adding a sense of hopelessness.

"a man struggling to maintain his humanity in a society ruled by the ever-watchful Big Brother."

- The contrast between "struggling to maintain his humanity" and "ever-watchful Big Brother" immediately emphasizes difficulty and conflict. There is no sense of hope in this struggle, which creates a feeling of futility.

Aside from Pessimistic, this blurb could also be interpreted as Suspenseful. While there are elements that could build tension, the primary focus of the blurb is on the hopelessness of Winston's situation and the inevitability of his defeat by the Party. The pessimistic tone dominates because it emphasizes despair and the futility of resistance rather than building anticipation or narrative tension about what will happen next.

Informative

Example

"From 70 of the most successful mystery writers in the business, an invaluable guide to crafting mysteries—from character development and plot to procedurals and thrillers—"this is a writing guide that readers and writers will turn to again and again" (Booklist, starred review). Mystery Writers of America (MWA) is known for providing unparalleled resources on the craft, art, and business of storytelling, helping writers of all levels improve their skills for nearly a century. Now, this handbook helps authors navigate the ever-shifting publishing landscape—from pacing, plotting, the business side of publishing, to the current demand for diversity and inclusivity across all genres, and more. Featuring essays by a new generation of bestselling experts on various elements of the craft and shorter pieces of crowd-sourced wisdom from the MWA membership as a whole, the topics covered can be categorized as follows: —Before Writing (rules; genres; setting; character; research; etc.) —While Writing (outlining; the plot; dialogue; mood; etc.) —After Writing (agents; editors; self-pub; etc.) —Other than Novels (short stories; true crime; etc.) —Other Considerations (diverse characters; legal questions; criticism) Also included is a collection of essays from MWA published authors—including Jeffery Deaver, Tess Gerritsen, and Charlaine Harris—selected by bestselling authors Lee Child and Laurie King and arranged thematically answering, "What piece of writing advice do you wish you'd had at the beginning of your career?" "Everything you wanted to know about how to plan, draft, write, revise, publish, and market a mystery" (Kirkus Reviews), this inclusive manual provides practical, current, easily digestible advice for new and established authors alike."

EXPLANATION

This blurb is an informative guide to writing mysteries, providing practical advice, industry insights, and expert contributions. Specific elements that contribute to this tone include:

"An invaluable guide to crafting mysteries—from character development and plot to procedurals and thrillers."

- Words like "invaluable guide", "unparalleled resources", and "practical" emphasize the helpful and educational nature of the Work which comes across as an educational resource.

"the topics covered can be categorized as follows:"

- The content of the work is a writing guide, which by nature is informative. The blurb also follows a clear and organized structure, listing the different topics covered in a methodical manner.

This other possible tone is Inspirational. While the blurb does have elements that could inspire, the primary focus is on providing factual, practical advice about writing, with little emphasis on personal growth or emotional uplift. The tone remains more pragmatic and educational.

Contact Info

Should annotators face any issues, they can contact any one of us using our emails below.

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